

Case Study 2: Appraisal

In the year 2075, as an archivist in the Pennsylvania Historical Society who specializes in the historical period of the early 21st century, I've been approached with several boxes of taped broadcasts from the year 2025 created by the local 6abc Philadelphia news station. These boxes of taped broadcasts approximate 1000 individual DigiBeta videotapes containing recordings from their weekday 6pm local news segment. While the Historical Society currently does have a digital betacam deck in our possession to view these tapes, lack of space is still a very relevant issue in archives in 2075. Although the Historical Society currently has six cubic feet worth of paper records from 6abc Philadelphia from the years 2005 to 2020, I do think the addition of videotapes are worthy of acquisition and do contain value for their practical contributions to the archive, but also the narrative they contribute to our understanding of what was news worthy in a specific area like Philadelphia and what was deemed as valuable enough to share with the masses in 2025.

Background

I reviewed a sample of tapes from three consecutive days from June 2, 2025, to June 4, 2025 to review both the quality of the tapes and to get a better understanding of what the content contained to appraise them for value and see if they would align with our archive before working towards acquisition. Below is a brief description of the content of the sample tapes.

The content of the tape for Monday, June 2, 2025, mostly highlighted news stories from Philadelphia and the surrounding area. The top story of the day reported on a body of a missing boater being discovered in the Schuylkill. Other stories included a woman caught stealing from an elementary school, the shooting and killing of a man in Center City during pride celebrations, the rescue of mistreated dogs and cats from a home in Olney, and the unveiling of a statue at Cherry Pier in honor of pride month. The local news also included a small segment on a top national news story which on this day was focused on the man responsible for the attack in Boulder, Colorado being charged with a federal hate crime (6abc, 2025).

Tuesday, June 3, 2025, began with the top story covering a triple shooting where the gunman used a semi-automatic to open fire on a car. Other stories focused on a family of a victim of a deadly police shooting filing wrongful death charges on the Abington police, a man in New Jersey being charged with theft for stealing fuel from the county to fuel up his personal side business trucks, a vigil held for the victims of a mass shooting in Fairmount Park last week during Memorial Day celebrations and the start of gun violence awareness month, a sinkhole in South Philadelphia, preparations underway for the FIFA Club World Cup matches hosted by the city of Philadelphia, and the effect of the federal Labor Department's cut on Job Corps in Philadelphia (6abc, 2025).

The Wednesday, June 4, 2025, 6abc at 6pm opened up with a story on a car crash in Limerick Pennsylvania that resulted in the death of three high school students after trying to evade the police in a police chase because of a reported theft at Target. The driver lost control of the car during the chase and crashed into a wall, resulting in the death of three of the four teens

in the car. Neighbors interviewed expressed sorrow and discomfort over the escalation to a full car chase because of reported shoplifting. Other stories included a man charged with murder for shooting his in-laws in their home while his children were present, a man accidentally firing a shot in his West Philadelphia apartment striking his downstairs neighbor in his bed, SEPTA's financial struggles and advocates heading to Harrisburg to request funding to avoid the cutting of routes, a shooting at a smoke shop in Kensington, the implementation of a law banning all handheld cellphone use while behind the wheel in Pennsylvania, local high school graduations, a hometown hero story focusing on a woman and her outreach program to help target addiction, and a sneak peek at a news segment that will take place at 11pm focusing on recent measles outbreaks and tracking how school vaccination rates have dropped in recent years (6abc, 2025).

Uniqueness and the Merits of Documentation

While there was no overlap or revisiting of news stories from the previous days, there were reoccurring themes witnessed across the videotape samples from these three days. One of the most obvious was Philadelphia's history and relationship with gun violence. All three news segments spent time on cases of gun violence within and around the city as well as a segment on the city's admission that gun violence is a large issue that needs to be tackled on a larger scale.

While the content of the videotape sample for the three days aren't especially unique in covering the top stories in Philadelphia at the time, as the larger Philadelphia focused stories were also being covered on other local news stations, a lot can be said of the uniqueness of the choices made to showcase these stories in the way that 6abc chose to do so. The decisions made on the specific sequences and timing of each news segment are unique decisions. Hughes discusses this in their concept of cultural mapping to account for the complex relationships between categories and systems. Institutions are not monoliths and should be understood as organizations shaped by a culture that affects decisions regarding the shaping of practices and institutional outputs (Hughes, 2014). There were also completely unique news segments that usually came in the form of hometown hero stories or individual or community highlights and also worked to provide insight into the culture of the news organization and what they deemed important.

News in the 21st century had a large digital presence at the time meaning that the stories covered in the local news could also be found in digital newspapers, on the radio, or as shortened news clips created by the news stations themselves and put online via their website or social media sites like YouTube to be consumed by those who might want shortened, more focused individual segments on the go. While the same news stories can be found in multiple places on the web, there is still merit to long form news in the structure of local news segments like 6abc. These 30-minute local news segments not only provide video footage that other forms of documentation like more text focused records might not, but do so in a way that provides context for what is occurring in multiple parts of both Philadelphia and the surrounding area at that particular time. It provides context in a way that shorter form, clip-based news reporting does not. MacNeil et al. speaks to the advantage of film in creating more robust, full pictures of a specific time frame (2018) and the inclusion of recordings of news segments does this in a structured way that we understand and are familiar with.

Appraisal Value

After viewing the sample DigiBeta tapes, and with a full understanding of what the Pennsylvania Historical Society collects based on their mission statement I believe that the news segments will be of value to the archives for a number of reasons, the first few being very practical reasons covered by Craig's theoretical framework of the internal context of practicing appraisal. These internal contexts include archivists' knowledge, resources and structures, and time and history (Craig, 2004).

As an archivist who specializes in the historical period of the early 21st century, it is very much in my wheelhouse to be able to appraise this collection for its value to the archive. I'm also cognizant enough of the shift in the political climate from the 2005-2020 records that we currently have from 6abc to recognize that not acquiring these records would result in a large gap within the archives that does not properly document a very historically important moment of political upheaval in the United States. This would result in stakeholders, like users of the archives and researchers not having access to a chronological continuation of records from 6abc and therefore lacking information on what 6abc news coverage looked like after 2020, which was a particularly disrupted year due to the Covid-19 pandemic and not at all indicative of what news station practices were in the rest of the 2020s.

The Historical Society currently does have in its possession the equipment needed to view the tapes and also contains the equipment to digitize these tapes and make them accessible to the public in the most current form of video recording. The archive currently has the structures in place to acquire these tapes and take on the project of converting them. However, it would be disingenuous to avoid the discussion surrounding whether we have the resources, and in this particular case, the manpower and space to take on all 1,000 videotapes. Archives do come with both limited space and personnel, and we currently do not have the time or manpower as a Historical Society to focus all of our attention on acquiring and reformatting all 1,000 individual videotapes. Decisions will have to be made regarding which of the tapes get kept and reformatted or are preserved in their original condition to be worked on later.

One of the most important aspects of the appraisal process in this situation is understanding the importance of time and history, or rather what value would be lost if both of those subjects went ignored. As Craig states, time and technology are interlinked when it comes to the discussion of records and have a large say in the values placed during the appraisal process (2004). In a situation like this, the importance of time is especially important because the news tapes reflect a particular place and time in video format and fill gaps for that historical time not currently covered in the archive, but also there is a fragility of time when it comes to the ticking time clock archivists have when dealing with specific formats of technology that run the risk of going increasingly obsolete as time passes. Wait too long and archives might no longer carry the equipment to view the records, making them unusable and therefore not valuable to the collection.

Beyond the practical reasons, the videos have been appraised as adding value to the collection for what they contribute to our understanding of history through the highlighted news

events of the time. Foscarini's four paradigms of archival appraisal, and specifically the second and third paradigm help frame the conversation of the value of the 6abc news DigiBeta tapes to our sense of meaning making. Foscarini's second paradigm, which is the memory paradigm builds on Schellenberg's concept of secondary value and highlights the ways in which records can act as a source of public memory (Foscarini, 2017). Essentially these tapes can have a large impact in the way researchers accessing these records from 2025 understand and make meaning of that particular time frame and location through the types of news stories covered, and the unspoken cultural aspects of the times made visible in the videos.

The third paradigm, or the identity paradigm, dives further and explores the ways in which records give insight into social norms and are part of the process of constructing social identities. "Because 'individuals...are unable to separate themselves from the sociohistorical conditions of their existence,' it follows that our behaviors and values are inescapably captive of the 'dominant values of society' (Booms, 1987, 74), whether we are aware of it or not" (Foscarini, 2017, pp.118). MacNeil et al. also explores the link between records and social identities and discusses the ways in which records have the ability to help people form an understanding of their senses of self within the surrounding society. Narrativity is how we make sense of the world and create our sense of social identity within it, but rarely are these social narratives of our own (MacNeil et al., 2018). The videotapes of the 6pm 6abc news segments are in an especially unique position to provide archive users with the ability to explore collective memory and form a narrative of the past through visuals that allow the creation of social identity but also acknowledge the way that this is formed within the constraints of societal norms given to us through an institution like a news agency. This ability to give users in 2075 the access to visually glimpse into what Philadelphia deemed important information to relay to the masses, and how that information itself was conveyed definitely merits both acquisition of the records and the allocation of resources to reformat some of the tapes into the latest form of video recordings that are widely accessible to the public.

The Acquisition Solution

However, while I do advocate for the value of these records for what they provide to the archive themselves, and wider society as a whole, I do have to be realistic about the time and resources it would take to store and reformat all 1000 videotapes at this time. Unfortunately, due to space and time constraints not all of the videos can be kept so decisions have to be made regarding how to move forward to decide which videos to keep without having to take the time to view all 1,000. Before taking on the project of sampling to select which of the video tapes will be kept, it is imperative to take photos of the collection to create a record of the sheer size and condition of the initial donation. Extra attention should also be taken to capture the labeling on each individual DigiBeta tape to capture the context and any other descriptions that the news network might have attached to each video. Network created labels and accompanying descriptions should be turned into a document used to describe the collection that will accompany the videotapes themselves to help researchers quickly search through the collection. After that information has been gathered it makes the most sense to use random sampling in this situation to avoid as much bias as possible. Random sampling works in this situation because the tapes are arranged chronologically by air date. While it may be the slower sampling option it

allows for the obtaining of a sample as representative of the entire collection as possible (Hunter, 2020). This is especially important in a case like this where we want to capture a sample that is representative of the timeframe as a whole and allows users to form as close of an idea as possible of what 6abc news looked like during this time and how it is situated in the wider world.

Conclusion

The sample of the three days of news coverage from June 2, 2025, to June 4, 2025, from 6abc Philadelphia's local news show at 6pm provide a great visual into what the region of Philadelphia was like 50 years ago and provides visual evidence of what news stories were deemed worthy of being shared. What 6abc news chose to show and the ways they decided to deliver these news stories give insight into the culture of the organization itself in a way that is unique to that institution. The 30-minute-long form of delivery of the local news also provides context into what was occurring at that time and strings together a narrative of Philadelphia in 2025. This visual narrative serves as a form of collective memory and social identity formation within a structure of societal norms. This invaluable visual narrative, as well as the gaps the DigiBeta tapes fill in the archive prove to be an invaluable record of information that will only serve to strengthen both the archives' collections and our understanding of the culture of city of Philadelphia in 2025. To account for the lack of space and personnel within the Pennsylvania Historical Society, a random sampling format should be used to select which of the 1,000 DigiBeta tapes will be kept to allow for the most representative sample of the entire collection as possible. The acquisition of these tapes will be a great additional insight into our understanding of 2025 through the lens of formatted television programming like 6abc Philadelphia news at 6pm.

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